Part 2: Core and Profiles

5. AI RMF Core

The AI RMF Core provides outcomes and actions that enable dialogue, understanding, and activities to manage AI risks and responsibly develop trustworthy AI systems. As illustrated in Figure 5, the Core is composed of four functions: **GOVERN, MAP, MEASURE,** and **MANAGE**. Each of these high-level functions is broken down into categories and subcategories. Categories and subcategories are subdivided into specific actions and outcomes. Actions do not constitute a checklist, nor are they necessarily an ordered set of steps.

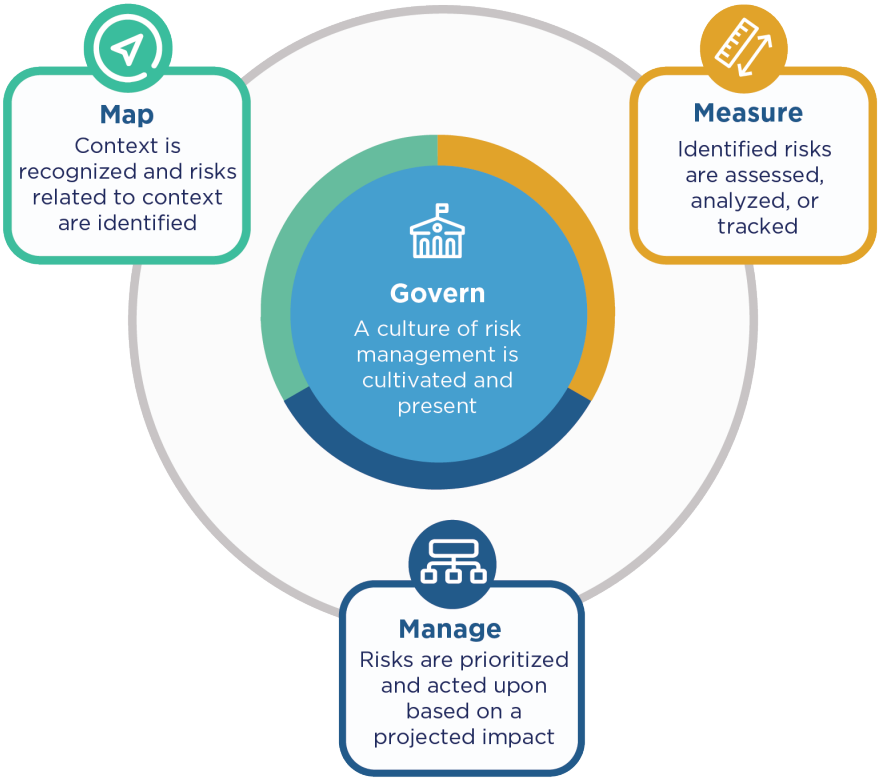


Fig. 5. Functions organize AI risk management activities at their highest level to govern, map, measure, and manage AI risks. Governance is designed to be a cross-cutting function to inform and be infused throughout the other three functions.

Risk management should be continuous, timely, and performed throughout the AI system lifecycle dimensions. AI RMF Core functions should be carried out in a way that reflects diverse and multidisciplinary perspectives, potentially including the views of AI actors outside the organization. Having a diverse team contributes to more open sharing of ideas and assumptions about purposes and functions of the technology being designed, developed,

deployed, or evaluated – which can create opportunities to surface problems and identify existing and emergent risks.

An online companion resource to the AI RMF, the NIST AI RMF Playbook, is available to help organizations navigate the AI RMF and achieve its outcomes through suggested tactical actions they can apply within their own contexts. Like the AI RMF, the Playbook is voluntary and organizations can utilize the suggestions according to their needs and interests. Playbook users can create tailored guidance selected from suggested material for their own use and contribute their suggestions for sharing with the broader community. Along with the AI RMF, the Playbook is part of the NIST Trustworthy and Responsible AI Resource Center.

Framework users may apply these functions as best suits their needs for managing AI risks based on their resources and capabilities. Some organizations may choose to select from among the categories and subcategories; others may choose and have the capacity to apply all categories and subcategories. Assuming a governance structure is in place, functions may be performed in any order across the AI lifecycle as deemed to add value by a user of the framework. After instituting the outcomes in **GOVERN**, most users of the AI RMF would start with the **MAP** function and continue to **MEASURE** or **MANAGE**. However users integrate the functions, the process should be iterative, with cross-referencing between functions as necessary. Similarly, there are categories and subcategories with elements that apply to multiple functions, or that logically should take place before certain subcategory decisions.

5.1 Govern

The **GOVERN** function:

- cultivates and implements a culture of risk management within organizations designing, developing, deploying, evaluating, or acquiring AI systems;
- outlines processes, documents, and organizational schemes that anticipate, identify, and manage the risks a system can pose, including to users and others across society – and procedures to achieve those outcomes;
- incorporates processes to assess potential impacts;
- provides a structure by which AI risk management functions can align with organizational principles, policies, and strategic priorities;
- connects technical aspects of AI system design and development to organizational values and principles, and enables organizational practices and competencies for the individuals involved in acquiring, training, deploying, and monitoring such systems; and
- addresses full product lifecycle and associated processes, including legal and other issues concerning use of third-party software or hardware systems and data.